

EPISODE ONE

The premise

v2, 2026-08-28. Stephen's rework, with three things folded in. Working title not settled. For Trish to read.

A woman dies in her own home. It is recorded as an accident, so nobody investigates, and within a few weeks it is simply a sad thing that happened to somebody.

She had four close friends. In the months before she died she had become frightened, because she had worked out that one of those four was planning to kill her. She hid what she had. She did not go to the police, partly because what she had was not quite proof, and mostly because taking it to them meant accusing somebody she loved. So she made an arrangement instead. If anything happened to her, all four of them would be sent a key.

After the funeral, the keys arrive in the post. All four of them go to the same place.

It is already empty.

So four people who loved her are left knowing one thing for certain: one of the other three got there first. They have nothing they can take to the police. What they have is each other, and the fact that between them they knew her better than anyone alive did. They start meeting. They start trying to work out which of them it is.

One of them gets close.

A few days later one of the four disappears. His car is found near the coast, at a spot the whole city knows people go to when they want to end things. His phone is left on the seat. No body is ever recovered, which is normal there.

And the woman who had been getting close stops.

Because there are only two ways to read it. Either she was wrong about him, or she was right and she drove a man off a cliff. She cannot live inside the second one, so she chooses the first, and she lets it go. It never stops bothering her.

Months later a stranger begins talking to her. He knows things about her friend's death that nobody has said out loud. He will not put any of it in writing. He says he will meet her and tell her the rest, and he names the place: the spot where the car was found.

She goes.

She falls onto the rocks and her body washes up in Havenbay harbour a few days later. There is nothing about her injuries that a fall does not explain, so nobody can say whether she was pushed or whether she jumped. And everybody has a reason ready, because she had spent months blaming herself for a friend who went off the same cliff.

Two of them are dead now and one has vanished, and the city settles on grief. Three friends, one after another. It happens.

But the two who are left know something the police do not, which is that she had accused one of the four, and there are only two of them still standing. Each of them is now certain it is the other. And each of them is

frightened enough to walk into a police station and say so.

Two people accusing each other of three deaths, neither able to account for where they were, is front page news. Ally's podcast picks it up a day later.

He is alive and he is somewhere else, under another name, and he thinks it is finished. He is not wrong to think so. He killed her, he removed the one person who was about to see it, he did it in a way that reads as grief, and he left behind two suspects who are doing the rest of the work for him.

Ally comes to all of this afterwards. She prevents nothing, and she could not have. What her podcast does, slowly, is establish that the man everybody has spent months mourning was never harmed at all.

She does not do it alone, and she could not have. Her listeners do it. A woman who cleaned that stretch of coast road. Somebody who kept a message the dead woman sent them and thought nothing of it at the time. And, eventually, somebody four hundred miles away who has been listening to a description of a man for six weeks and has slowly understood that she knows him, under a different name, and that he has been sitting across a table from her.

And that is what costs. Because the moment Ally proves he is alive, the two people who accused each other stop being suspects and become the only two people on earth who could identify him.

They are named. They are findable. And for the first time since he walked away from that cliff, he has a reason to come back.

What it is about

The woman who died second was the best of the four at seeing what was in front of her, and it killed her. The two who survived are the two who were not. They were spared because they were not good enough, and neither of them will ever say that out loud to the other.

And they spent months each certain the other one was going to kill them. They were both wrong.

Then Ally proved it, and made it true.

Still open, so you know what you can change

- **The title.** *Five Keys After Midnight* is retired. Current suggestion is *The Friend They Mourned*.
- **Who the four are.** Not decided at all. Fable writes them next, and deliberately will not be told which one did it, so that all four are written as people any of whom could be.
- **What she hid,** and how she came by it.
- **How long ago all of this happened,** and how long Ally's podcast runs for.
- **Which of the two survivors is which,** and whether either of them is anything to Ally already.
- **Where in Havenbay it sits,** including which stretch of coast.
- **How it ends.** Only that it should be honest about what it costs. They get their names back. They do not get their friendship back, and the woman who died was right all along and nobody told her.

Settled, and expensive to move: four friends rather than five · her death recorded as an accident · the place already empty when they get there · him vanishing before the second death rather than after · the stranger who baits her back · her injuries explaining themselves · Ally arriving after all of it · the listeners finding the pieces.